adds. Ratan asked Chandrasekaran, ‘Can you run it as a financially viable [company]?’

When bids were invited for the first time in 2018, 76 per cent equity was offered in Air India. There was, however, not enough clarity in the proposal and the government got no bids. The Tata Group did not step back. It continued to work hard to have Air India return to its original home. Besides giving the ministry extensive inputs when it was sought from potential bidders, it constituted a team of nearly 100–150 experts in the field for over eighteen months to study the possible acquisition from various angles.

In 2020, the government invited Expressions of Interest for a 100 per cent sale of the airline. In September 2021, during the second bidding process, seven prospective buyers entered the fray but only two qualified—Talace Pvt. Ltd, a wholly owned subsidiary of Tata Sons, and a consortium led by the promoter of SpiceJet airline, Ajay Singh. Three weeks later, on 8 October 2021, Tata Sons emerged the winner with its bid of Rs 18,000 crore.

Nearly seven decades after it had been nationalized, JRD’s most favourite creation was brought back home. Ratan rejoiced that day, posting a memorable picture of JRD on a tarmac in front of an Air India plane, on social media. He also tweeted, ‘Welcome back, Air India’ and added that the group was committed to restoring the airline to its past glory.

Speaking to me, he says, ‘Air India meant a lot to JRD’ who ‘led the airline to become’ one of the best in the world. Bringing it back to the Tatas was an ‘extremely emotional event’. He also expresses confidence that the group will be able to turn around the airline with the right professionals chosen to manage the company. Air India would now be at the ‘forefront’ of world aviation, he adds. ‘He [Ratan] was very emotionally happy’; ‘it meant a lot to him that we could get it back,’ emphasizes Chandrasekaran, making it clear that he too was driven to achieve the same goal. According to him, the airline is an enduring symbol of the Tatas. ‘If you close your eyes and think of the Tata Group’, you cannot miss the image of JRD in front of the Air India plane, he says. ‘For me, it was a special moment. It was natural justice.’

On 27 January 2022, Tata Sons formally took charge of Air India. JRD’s anguished words to Prime Minister Nehru in 1952—‘I am sincerely convinced that the Ministry’s [government’s] present nationalisation